



Arundhati Bhattacharya
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From SBI to Salesforce

Arundhati Bhattacharya on Women in Tech leadership

Jayesh Shinde | editor@digit.in

There's a certain quiet authority in the way Arundhati Bhattacharya tells her story. Not as a sequence of milestones, but as a series of moments where someone chose to believe. It's a theme that runs through her journey, from walking into the corridors of State Bank of India in 1977 — when leadership pathways for women were at best undefined — to now steering Salesforce South Asia at a time when technology leadership itself is being rewritten in real time with AI disruptions.

Bhattacharya's perspective is unique because it highlights both sides of India's leadership equation — the structured public sector institutions and the more fluid tech industry. Her insights land on uncomfortable truths about leadership pipelines, waiting for opportunities, and merit alone dictating who gets a seat at the table.

And yet, Bhattacharya's optimistic. What follows is a verbatim Q&A, in many ways, a blueprint for what it will take to move 'Women in Tech' from representation to real influence.

Q What barriers continue to hold women back from the C-suite in tech?

A Arundhati Bhattacharya: Women exit or plateau between ages 28-35, precisely when leadership tracks accelerate. We promote availability over capability, and that math never works in women's favour. Sometimes, C-suite decisions happen in golf clubs and informal circles where women simply aren't present. You can't mentor your way out of structural exclusion.

India has women in tech roles, but look at the org charts. They're in support functions. The P&L owners, the revenue drivers, the product chiefs? Still overwhelmingly male. The fix

isn't workshops. It's mandates. Until we treat gender equity like we treat quarterly earnings — with metrics, accountability, and consequences — the C-suite will remain exactly what it is: a closed loop that replicates itself.

Q What skills will determine who leads in this new AI era?

A Arundhati Bhattacharya: Technology will keep evolving, but some fundamentals remain constant. First, build deep competence. Credibility comes from understanding your craft and delivering consistently. Whether someone is working with cloud platforms, AI, or data, strong technical foundations will always matter. At the same time, leadership in this new era will require curiosity and adaptability. Technologies change very quickly, so the ability to keep learning and evolve with them becomes just as important as you already know.

Equally important are skills such as collaboration, communication and the confidence to speak up with your perspective. The most effective leaders in technology will not just understand the tools, they will understand how those tools can solve real problems and create value.

Q If we fast-forward ten years, what would success actually look like for women in India's technology ecosystem?

A Arundhati Bhattacharya: Ten years from now, success would mean that women's leadership in technology is no longer seen as an exception. It would be entirely normal to see women leading teams, building startups and shaping decisions in boardrooms. I am optimistic because the pipeline is already stronger. More women are entering STEM and the next generation is far more confident about where they belong. **d**

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